

The Dhāraṇī of Retention and Memory

Toh 792 · Derge Kangyur

This brief text is a dhāraṇī, a short mantra-based ritual formula, whose title is rendered in the translation's closing line as the dhāraṇī for a melodious voice; the Tibetan title appears to be a name of the goddess of memory and learning, though no Sanskrit title is given in the material at hand. It opens with homage to the Three Jewels and a mantra addressed to a goddess associated with hearing and remembering, then sets out a simple practice: over seven days, in front of the noble Avalokiteśvara, one empowers a vessel of water seven times with the mantra and drinks it. The stated benefits are a remarkable memory, with three hundred śloka's worth of text learned in a single day, and, after a month of practice, a voice as sweet as that of a kinnara. It is Toh 792 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the Tantra section as one of the many short dhāraṇīs and ritual procedures preserved in the canon for practical, worldly aims such as learning and eloquence.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Oṃ bhagavati śruti smṛti, bala bala paramasiddhe svāhā.

The procedure is as follows. For a period of seven days, make the preparation, and in the presence of the noble Avalokiteśvara, the Sovereign Lord, take a vessel of water, empower it seven times with the mantra, and drink it. Then in a single day one will be able to memorize three hundred śloka's worth of text.

If one practices for a period of one month, one's voice will become as melodious as that of a kinnara, and one should have no doubt about this.

Thus ends the dhāraṇī for a melodious voice.

Translator's Notes

- The mantra is transmitted in corrupt Tibetan transcription, so the Sanskrit above is a tentative reconstruction. "Bhagavati" is likely, while "śruti smṛti" (hearing, memory) fits the dhāraṇī's purpose. The syllables "bala bala parama siddhe" are rendered as they stand. The phrase "make the preparation" renders a line whose exact sense is uncertain in the Tibetan, possibly meaning to purify oneself or make offerings beforehand. The "kinnara" is my rendering of a Tibetan term that literally reads "human or what," the traditional Tibetan gloss of the Sanskrit kiṃnara, a celestial musician, so the sense of a sweet singing voice is secure. The phrase "memorize three hundred śloka's worth of text" interprets a somewhat compressed line about the number of letters or verses retained in a day.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.